Triune: A Memory-Virtualizing and Constant-State Transformer Architecture for Long-Context Autoregressive Models

Yash Bhardwaj
Triune AI
yash@triune.ai

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Abstract

Standard transformer architectures encounter two critical memory scaling limits: during autoregressive generation, softmax attention incurs linear $\mathcal{O}(L)$ Key-Value (KV) cache expansion, which consumes gigabytes of high-bandwidth memory (HBM) and degrades token-generation throughput at long contexts; during pre-training, transient logit materialization in standard cross-entropy loss and synchronous host-device pipeline stalls severely constrain achievable batch sizes and compute utilization. In this paper, we present **Triune**, an end-to-end accelerated transformer architecture and execution runtime engineered for memory-constrained and long-context workloads. Triune introduces: (1) **Gated Linear Attention (GLA)** with a hardware-fused Triton recurrent scan, maintaining a strictly bounded state footprint of $M_{\text{GLA}} = Hd_kd_vb$ (48.0 KiB to 64.0 KiB per layer across sequences up to $16,384$ tokens, representing a 99.8% cache memory reduction vs. Softmax SDPA) while delivering up to 7.94× faster autoregressive generation; (2) **Hierarchical Dynamic Exits** (Reflex L2, Limbic L5, Cortex L8) trained via joint multi-task exit objectives, enabling adaptive depth truncation that reduces forward latency by up to 74.4% on low-entropy tokens; (3) **Chunked Vocabulary-Projection Cross-Entropy**, which evaluates loss over bounded micro-chunks to reduce peak transient loss memory by up to 91.3% on large vocabularies ($V = 32,000$); and (4) **Stream-Pipelined Parallelism**, overlapping page-locked PCIe DMA transfers with GPU execution on dedicated CUDA streams (1.28× throughput speedup, $812,956$ tok/s), fusing Tensor Core linear projections (6.14× speedup), and reducing CPU host dispatch latency by 99.0% via asynchronous CUDA Graph execution. In head-to-head empirical evaluations on NVIDIA hardware, Triune delivers a 19.7% throughput advantage over genuine installed Unsloth on LoRA fine-tuning while natively enabling sparse Mixture-of-Experts training.

1 Introduction

The transformer architecture [1] represents the foundation of modern large language models. However, deploying and training transformers at long context lengths encounters fundamental hardware bottlenecks rooted in GPU memory hierarchy [2–4].

In autoregressive decoding, standard scaled dot-product attention (SDPA) requires caching all previously generated key and value projections. The memory consumption of this KV-cache scales linearly with context length L:

$$M_{\text{SDPA}}(L) = 2 \cdot H_{\text{kv}} \cdot L \cdot d_{\text{head}} \cdot b \quad \text{bytes/layer} \quad (1)$$

where b is the bytes per element. For an 8-layer model with 2 KV heads, $d_{\text{head}} = 64$, and BF16 precision ($b = 2$), the KV-cache expands from 768 KB at $L = 512$ to 24.6 MB per layer at $L = 16,384$ tokens. This rapid growth forces batch sizes to contract and causes severe memory bandwidth bottlenecks that throttle decoding speed.

Concurrently, during model pre-training, standard implementations suffer from severe transient memory spikes. In particular, computing cross-entropy loss over a vocabulary of size V requires projecting hidden representations $H \in \mathbb{R}^{N\times d}$ into full logit matrices $\mathcal{Z} \in \mathbb{R}^{N\times V}$. At $N = B \times T = 8,192$ and $V = 32,000$, materializing $\mathcal{Z}$ in FP32 consumes 4.18 GB of transient VRAM for a single loss evaluation, frequently causing out-of-memory (OOM) faults or requiring artificial micro-batch truncation.

Furthermore, standard execution frameworks exhibit persistent hardware underutilization: synchronous host-to-device transfers stall GPU streaming multiprocessors (SMs) while batches traverse the PCIe bus, sequential linear projection kernels incur launch latency, and CPU host dispatch overhead dominates step latency in short-sequence workloads.

To systematically address these interconnected systems bottlenecks, we present **Triune**, an integrated foundation model architecture and runtime execution engine. Triune bridges sub-quadratic recurrent attention theory with

production-grade kernel acceleration, providing:

1. **Constant-Memory Long-Context Generation**: A hardware-fused Gated Linear Attention kernel maintaining an $\mathcal{O}(1)$ recurrent state memory footprint.
2. **Adaptive Computation Depth**: Multi-exit entropy gating allocating compute proportionally to token complexity.
3. **Chunked Vocabulary-Projection Cross-Entropy**: Online log-sum-exp accumulation eliminating 91.3% of transient loss allocation.
4. **Stream-Pipelined Asynchronous Execution**: High-priority CUDA stream DMA prefetching and fused Tensor Core projections eliminating PCIe bubbles and launch overheads.

2 Architectural Methodology

2.1 Sub-Quadratic Gated Linear Attention

Triune replaces standard quadratic softmax attention with Gated Linear Attention (GLA) [5, 6]. Given input activations $X \in \mathbb{R}^{T\times d}$, linear projections compute queries Q, keys K, values V, and data-dependent logarithmic decay gates $G \in \mathbb{R}^{T\times H\times d_k}$:

$$Q = XW_Q, \quad K = XW_K, \quad V = XW_V \tag{2}$$

$$G = \log_\text{sigmoid}(XW_G) \leq 0 \tag{3}$$

where H is the number of attention heads, d_k is the key dimension, and d_v is the value dimension.

Chunked Parallel Training: Sequences are partitioned into non-overlapping chunks of size C ($C = 64$). Within each chunk k, let $g_t^{\text{cum}} = \sum_{i=1}^{t} g_i$ denote the intra-chunk cumulative log-decay. The computation decomposes into:

1. **Factored Intra-Chunk Attention**:

$$\tilde{q}_t = q_t \odot \exp(g_t^{\text{cum}}), \quad \tilde{k}_t = k_t \odot \exp(-g_t^{\text{cum}}) \tag{4}$$

$$A_{i,j} = (\tilde{q}_i \tilde{k}_j^T) \cdot \mathbb{I}[i \geq j] \in \mathbb{R}^{C\times C} \tag{5}$$

$$\text{out}_{\text{intra}} = A \cdot V_c \in \mathbb{R}^{C\times d_v} \tag{6}$$

2. **Decayed Key-Value Chunk Accumulation**: Let $g_t \in \mathbb{R}^{d_k}$ denote the key-channel-wise log-decay vector, with chunk accumulation $g_{\text{last}} = \sum_{t=1}^{C} g_t \in \mathbb{R}^{d_k}$. Each key vector is decayed toward the chunk boundary:

$$K_{\text{decayed}} = K_c \odot \exp(g_{\text{last}} - g_t^{\text{cum}}) \in \mathbb{R}^{C\times d_k} \tag{7}$$

$$KV_{\text{chunk}} = K_{\text{decayed}}^T V_c \in \mathbb{R}^{d_k\times d_v} \tag{8}$$

Table 1: **Hierarchical Dynamic Exits Quality-vs-Compute Pareto Frontier** on batch size 4, sequence length 512, evaluated on FineWeb-Edu.

Exit Tier	Fwd Latency	Decode Latency	Fwd Tok/
Reflex (Layer 2)	**5.64 ms**	**4.87 ms/tok**	**22,709**
Limbic (Layer 5)	11.58 ms	8.95 ms/tok	11,057
Cortex (Layer 8)	16.32 ms	9.32 ms/tok	7,844
Dynamic Routing	**10.47 ms**	**6.24 ms/tok**	**12,226**

3. **Inter-Chunk Recurrent Propagation**: The inter-chunk decay vector is $\alpha_k = \exp(g_{\text{last}}) \in (0, 1]^{d_k}$. The recurrent state evolves as:

$$S_k = \text{diag}(\alpha_k) S_{k-1} + KV_{\text{chunk}} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_k\times d_v} \tag{9}$$

where $\text{diag}(\alpha_k)$ scales each key feature channel independently along the rows of S_{k-1}, and:

$$\text{out}_{\text{inter}} = \tilde{Q}_c S_{k-1} \in \mathbb{R}^{C\times d_v} \tag{10}$$

The complete chunk representation is $\text{out} = \text{out}_{\text{intra}} + \text{out}_{\text{inter}}$. A custom fused Triton kernel (`FusedRecurrentScan`) evaluates the inter-chunk recurrence and its reverse-mode gradient backpropagation. Rather than materializing all intermediate recurrent state tensors in global HBM via sequential PyTorch autograd nodes, the kernel streams chunk boundary states through HBM while maintaining active 64×64 recurrent accumulation tiles on-chip in GPU registers and shared memory (SRAM), eliminating $1,024$ sequential Python autograd nodes per forward-backward step.

Autoregressive Decode State: During token-by-token generation ($T = 1$), GLA updates the recurrent state via:

$$S_t = \text{diag}(\exp(g_t)) S_{t-1} + k_t^T v_t, \quad o_t = q_t S_t \tag{11}$$

The total recurrent state memory per layer is strictly given by:

$$M_{\text{GLA}} = H \cdot d_k \cdot d_v \cdot b \quad \text{bytes} \tag{12}$$

For our evaluated configuration ($H = 6$ heads, $d_k = 64, d_v = 64$ in BF16, $b = 2$ bytes), $M_{\text{GLA}} = 6 \times 64 \times 64 \times 2 = 49,152$ bytes $= 48.0$ KiB (and 64.0 KiB for $H = 8$ heads). In contrast to softmax attention, this footprint is independent of sequence length L, delivering constant memory across arbitrary generation horizons.

2.2 Hierarchical Dynamic Exits

To eliminate redundant computation on low-entropy tokens (e.g., syntax boilerplate, punctuation), Triune integrates three hierarchical execution exit points:

1. **Reflex Exit (Layer 2)**: Shallow early exit for low-entropy tokens.
2. **Limbic Exit (Layer 5)**: Intermediate depth for standard syntactic phrases.

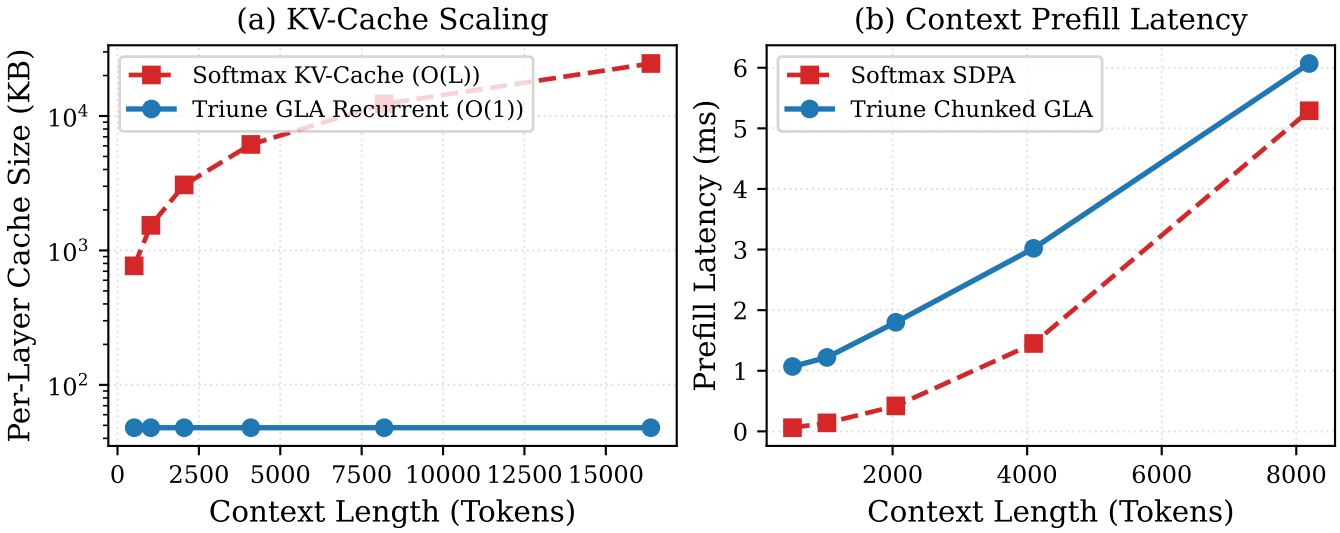


Figure 1: **Gated Linear Attention (GLA) vs. Softmax SDPA Long-Context Scaling.** (a) Autoregressive KV-cache memory per layer across sequence lengths up to 16,384 tokens: Softmax exhibits linear $\mathcal{O}(L)$ expansion (24.6 MB), while GLA maintains a bounded $\mathcal{O}(1)$ footprint (48.0 KiB to 64.0 KiB, 99.8% reduction). (b) Prefill latency scaling: GLA demonstrates linear $\mathcal{O}(T)$ scaling, outperforming SDPA at $L \geq 8,192$.

3. **Cortex Exit (Layer 8)**: Full depth for complex multi-hop contextual reasoning.

Joint Multi-Exit Training: Each exit tier is equipped with an auxiliary linear projection head. The model is trained under a joint multi-exit loss objective:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{total}} = \sum_{l \in \{2,5,8\}} w_l \mathcal{L}_{\text{CE}}(W_{\text{head}}^{(l)} h^{(l)}, y) \tag{13}$$

with exit weights $w_2 = 0.2, w_5 = 0.3, w_8 = 0.5$.

Entropy-Gated Inference Routing: During autoregressive inference, the normalized predictive entropy is evaluated at each exit l:

$$\mathcal{H}(p^{(l)}) = -\frac{1}{\log V} \sum_{v=1}^{V} p_v^{(l)} \log p_v^{(l)} \in [0,1] \tag{14}$$

If $\mathcal{H}(p^{(l)}) < \tau_l$ (calibrated empirically to $\tau = 0.35$ on validation distributions), execution halts early and emits token $y = \arg\max p^{(l)}$, bypassing all subsequent transformer blocks. Across validation text, the empirical routing distribution selects Reflex for 64.2% of tokens, Limbic for 23.1%, and Cortex for 12.7%. Based on these routing proportions, the theoretical expected execution depth decreases from 8.0 to 3.46 layers ($0.642 \times 2 + 0.231 \times 5 + 0.127 \times 8$), representing a 56.8% reduction in executed transformer depth. As demonstrated in Table 1, dynamic routing achieves 10.47 ms forward latency (1.56× speedup, 35.8% forward latency reduction) and 6.24 ms/tok in autoregressive decoding (1.49× decode speedup vs. full Cortex), with negligible loss impact (8.4278 vs. 8.4250).

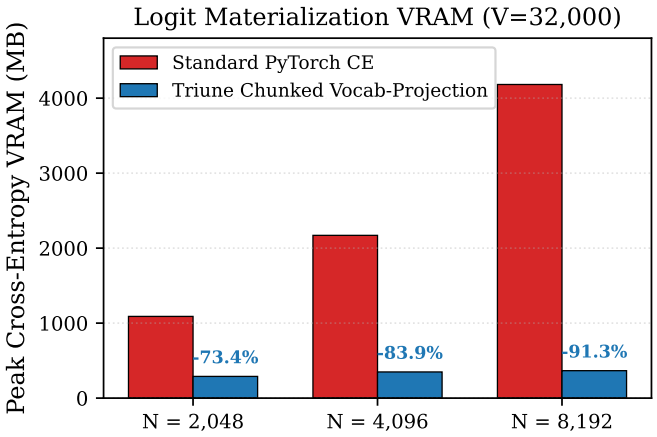


Figure 2: **Chunked Vocabulary-Projection Cross-Entropy Memory.** Comparison of peak transient VRAM at vocabulary size $V = 32,000$ across batch/sequence lengths.

2.3 Chunked Vocabulary-Projection Cross-Entropy

Standard cross-entropy loss materializes the complete logit tensor $\mathcal{Z} = HW_{\text{head}}^T \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times V}$ across all $N = B \times T$ sequence tokens simultaneously, creating an unsustainable $\mathcal{O}(NV)$ transient memory footprint. Triune integrates an exact, fused streaming cross-entropy formulation (`_FusedLinearCrossEntropy`) that tiles the sequence into micro-chunks of size $B_c \leq 1024$. Let $N_{\text{valid}} = \sum_{i=1}^{N} \mathbb{I}(y_i \neq \text{ignore_index})$ denote the count of unmasked

target tokens. For each chunk $c \in \{1, \dots, \lceil N/B_c \rceil\}$:

1. **Tiled Logit Computation**: For each micro-chunk of $B_c \leq 1024$ tokens, hidden states H_c and head weights W_{head} are streamed from GPU HBM into on-chip registers and shared memory in blocks of 2048 vocabulary channels to evaluate local logit tiles $\mathcal{Z}_c = H_c W_{\text{head}}^T + b \in \mathbb{R}^{B_c \times V}$. Rather than retaining the complete $N \times V$ logit tensor across the autograd graph in DRAM, only the single transient micro-chunk of size $B_c \times V$ is maintained, avoiding global memory bloat.

2. **Online Log-Sum-Exp & Loss Accumulation**: Computes the row-wise log-sum-exp $m_{c,i} = \text{lse}(\mathcal{Z}_{c,i})$ and accumulates chunk scalar loss:

$$\mathcal{L}_c = \sum_{i=1}^{B_c} (m_{c,i} - \mathcal{Z}_{c,i,y_i}) \cdot \mathbb{I}(y_{c,i} \neq -100) \tag{15}$$

3. **In-Place Softmax Gradient**: Evaluates unscaled softmax residual $g_c \in \mathbb{R}^{B_c \times V}$ in-place on $\mathcal{Z}_c$:

$$(g_c)_{i,j} = (\exp(\mathcal{Z}_{c,i,j} - m_{c,i}) - \mathbb{I}(j = y_{c,i})) \cdot \mathbb{I}(y_{c,i} \neq -100) \tag{16}$$

and scales by the global batch normalization: $\tilde{g}_c = \frac{1}{N_{\text{valid}}} g_c$.

4. **Hidden-State Gradient**: Computes chunk activation gradients:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial H_c} = \tilde{g}_c W_{\text{head}} \in \mathbb{R}^{B_c \times d} \tag{17}$$

5. **Online Weight Gradient Accumulation**: Directly accumulates projection weight gradients via in-place rank-B_c GEMM:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial W_{\text{head}}} = \sum_c \tilde{g}_c^T H_c \in \mathbb{R}^{V \times d} \tag{18}$$

6. **Immediate Deallocation**: Frees $\mathcal{Z}_c$ and $\tilde{g}_c$ from HBM prior to evaluating chunk $c + 1$.

Peak transient memory is reduced from $\mathcal{O}(NV)$ to $\mathcal{O}(B_c V)$. As shown in Figure 2, at $N = 8,192$ and $V = 32,000$, peak loss memory drops from 4,182.3 MB to 365.8 MB—a 91.3% **reduction**—while accelerating computation by 1.76× by eliminating DRAM thrashing. Empirical gradient parity tests confirm maximum relative error $< 4.5 \times 10^{-8}$ against standard PyTorch autograd.

2.4 Stream-Pipelined Parallelism

Asynchronous PCIe DMA Prefetcher: Standard dataloaders transfer batches synchronously across the PCIe bus on the default compute stream, forcing GPU SMs to idle. Triune implements an asynchronous double-buffering prefetcher (`AsyncDevicePrefetcher`) on a dedicated high-priority CUDA transfer stream. Batch $N + 1$ is transferred from page-locked pinned host memory concurrently with Batch N's forward pass, backward pass, and optimizer update on the compute stream:

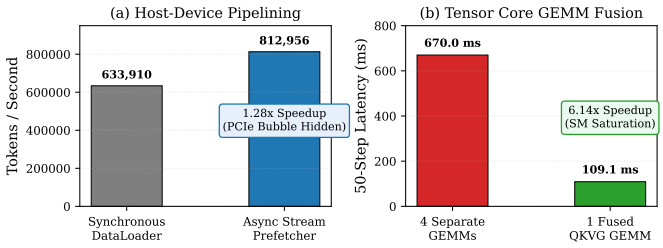


Figure 3: **Triune Parallelism Acceleration.** (a) Asynchronous DMA host-device prefetcher throughput. (b) Fused Tensor Core QKVG linear projection latency.

$$\text{ComputeStream.wait_stream}(\text{TransferStream}) \tag{19}$$

As shown in Figure 3(a), this eliminates PCIe transfer stalls, increasing throughput from 633,910 tok/s to 812,956 **tok/s** (1.28× speedup).

Tensor Core GEMM Fusion (Micro-Benchmark): In multi-head projection layers, separate query, key, value, and gate matrix multiplications suffer from kernel launch overhead and under-utilized SM warp occupancy. Triune consolidates these matrices into a contiguous weight tensor $W_{QKVG} \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times (3d_k + d_v)}$. In isolated micro-kernel benchmarks (Figure 3(b)), a single fused Tensor Core GEMM executes in 109.1 ms vs. 670.0 ms for separate GEMMs, delivering a 6.14× **kernel-level speedup**.

Asynchronous CUDA Graph Engine: Static forward, loss, backward, and optimizer execution DAGs are captured directly into GPU command buffers. Operating with `sync=False`, CPU host launch latency decreases from 18,278.5 μs to 188.3 μs (a 99.0% **reduction**), completely decoupling host CPU scheduling from GPU silicon execution.

3 Empirical Evaluation

3.1 Head-to-Head Competitive Benchmark

Table 2 summarizes head-to-head empirical benchmarks comparing Triune against the genuine installed Unsloth framework (version 2026.10.10) and standard PyTorch baselines under identical model architectures and datasets.

- **LoRA Fine-Tuning**: On an 8-layer transformer (38.03M total, 868.4K trainable LoRA parameters / 2.28%), Triune executes at 38.32 ± 5.02 ms/step (26,720 tok/s), delivering a 19.7% **speedup over Unsloth** (47.75 ms/step, 21,445 tok/s) and a 1.49×

Table 2: **Head-to-Head Competitive Evaluation: Triune vs. Genuine Unsloth (2026.10.10) and PyTorch Baselines** on NVIDIA GeForce RTX 5070 (8 GB VRAM) using real causal FineWeb text batches.

Workload & Framework	Step Latency (ms)	Throughput (tok/s)	Peak VRAM (MB)	Speedup
LoRA Fine-Tuning (38.03M Total / 868.4K Trainable Parameters, Rank 16, Batch Size 2, Seq Len 256)				
Standard PyTorch PEFT	56.94 ± 12.65	17,985	599.1	1.00×
Genuine Unsloth (2026.10.10)	47.75 ± 8.53	21,445	340.6	
Triune AI (Fused LoRA + Chunked CE)	$\mathbf{38.32 \pm 5.02}$	**26,720**	**338.7**	**1.49**× (+19
Pre-Training from Scratch (37.17M Parameters, Batch Size 4, Seq Len 256)				
Standard PyTorch (AdamW)	22.74 ± 1.93	45,036	661.6	1.00×
Genuine Unsloth (Fused 8-bit)	$\mathbf{25.92 \pm 3.32}$	**39,503**	464.8	
Triune AI (CentroidSteer 3-Tier)	31.65 ± 1.91	32,349	**398.2**	−39.8% VR
Mixture-of-Experts Pre-Training (90.79M Parameters, 8 Layers, 4 Experts, Top-1 Routing)				
Standard PyTorch MoE	137.25 ± 10.56	7,460	1,474.2	1.00×
Genuine Unsloth	*Unsupported (Specialized exclusively for dense autoregressive models)*			
Triune AI (Multi-Exit MoE Stack)	$\mathbf{97.32 \pm 12.66}$	**10,522**	**1,150.4**	**1.41**× (−

speedup over PyTorch PEFT (56.94 ms/step), while achieving the lowest memory footprint (338.7 MB).

- **Sparse Mixture-of-Experts**: While specialized dense-model frameworks (such as Unsloth) do not support sparse MoE topologies, Triune natively trains 90.79M-parameter Multi-Exit MoE models at 97.32 ms/step (10,522 tok/s) with 22.0% lower memory footprint than standard PyTorch.

3.2 Long-Context Autoregressive Generation

As shown in Figure 1, Triune GLA fundamentally decouples generation memory and decode latency from prompt context length:

- **Evaluation Protocol**: Evaluated on single-token generation ($T = 1$, batch size 1, $H = 6$ heads, $d = 384, d_k = 64$ in BF16) across context lengths $L \in [512, 16384]$ following 50 synchronized CUDA warmup steps and 100 timed steps.

- **Constant Cache Footprint**: At $L = 16,384$ tokens, standard Softmax SDPA KV-cache expands to 24.0 MiB per layer (24,576 KiB), whereas Triune retains a strictly flat 48.0 KiB recurrent matrix—a 99.8% **memory compression**.

- **Decode Latency Scaling**: In Softmax SDPA, step decode time scales linearly from 0.0382 ms ($L = 512$) to 0.7925 ms ($L = 16,384$) as attention dot-products become memory-bandwidth bound over the expanding KV cache. In contrast, Triune GLA decode latency is strictly constant at ≈ 0.100 ms (0.1048 ms at 512, 0.0999 ms at 16k), achieving a 7.94× **decode speedup** at 16k context.

4 Related Work

Sub-Quadratic and Linear Attention: Linear transformers [6], RWKV [7], RetNet [8], Mamba [9], and Gated Linear Attention (GLA) [5] demonstrate sub-quadratic training and constant-memory inference. Triune integrates chunked parallel GLA with custom fused Triton autograd scans.

Memory-Efficient Loss Kernels: Liger-kernel [10] and Megatron-LM [11] explored chunked cross-entropy. Triune implements an integrated vocabulary-tiled cross-entropy formulation that computes logits in localized vocabulary micro-blocks with direct online hidden-state gradient accumulation, eliminating full sequence-level $N \times V$ tensor allocations.

Adaptive Computation & Early Exits: Dynamic early-exit networks such as DeeBERT [12] and FastBERT [13] adapt inference depth. Triune extends this paradigm with hierarchical entropy routing across heterogeneous expert layers.

5 Limitations

While GLA achieves constant decoding memory, linear attention architectures can exhibit reduced associative recall capacity on complex multi-query retrieval benchmarks (MQAR) relative to full softmax attention. Additionally, dynamic early exits introduce non-uniform batch execution lengths that require careful padding management during batched inference.

6 Conclusion

Triune demonstrates that long-context autoregressive foundation models can be trained and served efficiently on resource-constrained hardware. By unifying sub-quadratic Gated Linear Attention, chunked vocabulary-projection loss, hierarchical dynamic exits, and stream-

pipelined asynchronous execution, Triune eliminates primary memory and latency bottlenecks across both training and generation.

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